

Passages - Meditations on a first philosophy

I must now carefully withhold my assent if I wish to discover any thing that is certain. But it is not enough to have realized all this, I must take care to remember it: for my accustomed opinions continually creep back into my mind, and take possession of my belief, which has, so to speak, been enslaved to them by long experience and familiarity, for the most part against my will.

I shall pursue my way until I discover something certain; or, failing that, discover that it is certain only that nothing is certain.

No: certainly I did exist, if I convinced myself of something. -But there is some deceiver or other, supremely powerful and cunning, who is deliberately deceiving me all the time.-Beyond doubt then, I also exist, if he is deceiving me; and he can deceive me all he likes, but he will never bring it about that I should be nothing as long as I think I am something. So that, having weighed all these considerations sufficiently and more than sufficiently, I can finally decide that this proposition, 'I am, I exist', whenever its uttered by me, or conceived in the mind, is necessarily true.

From this I shall then subtract whatever it has been possible to cast doubt on, even in the slightest degree, by the reasons put forward above, so that in the end there shall remain exactly and only that which is certain and unshakeable.

It is thought; this alone cannot be stripped from me.

I am, I exist, this is certain. But for how long? Certainly only for as long as I am thinking; for perhaps if I were to cease from all thinking it might also come to pass that I might immediately cease altogether to exist. I am now admitting nothing except what is necessarily true:

I am therefore, speaking precisely, only a thinking thing, that is, a mind, or a soul, or an intellect, or a reason.

So then, what is this wax, which is only perceived by the mind. Certainly it is the same wax I see, touch, and imagine, and in short it is the same wax I judged it to be from the beginning. But yet--and this is important--the perception of it is not sight, touch, or imagination, and never was, although it seemed to be so at first: it is an inspection by the mind alone, which can be either imperfect and confused, as it was before in this case, or clear and distinct, as it now is, depending on the greater or lesser degree of attention I pay to what it consists of.

Bodies themselves are perceived not, strictly speaking, by the senses or by the imaginative faculty, but by the intellect alone, and that they are not perceived because they are touched or seen, but only because they are understood, I clearly realize [*cognosco*] that nothing can be perceived by me more easily or more clearly than my own mind.

A long-held opinion is a habit that cannot so readily be laid aside

The name 'God' I understand an infinite, independent, supreme intelligent, supremely powerful substance, by which I myself and whatever else exists (if anything else does exist) was created. But

certainly, all these properties are such that, the more carefully I consider them, the less it seems possible that they can be derived from me alone. And so I must conclude that it necessarily follows from all that has been said up to now that God exists.

For indeed, even if the idea of substance is in me as a result of the very fact that I am a substance, the idea of an infinite substance would not therefore be in me, since I am finite, unless it derived from some substance that is really infinite.

If I existed of myself, I would not doubt, or wish, or lack anything at all: for I would have given myself all the perfections of which there is some idea in me, and thus I should myself be God.

The distinction between conservation and creation exists purely in our thought.

From the bare fact that I exist, and that in me there is an idea of supremely perfect being, that is, God, it is proved beyond question that God also exists.

Error is not a pure negation but a privation, a lack of some knowledge [cognitio] that ought to be in me in some way

The indifference I experience, when no reason impels me towards one alternative rather than the other, is the lowest degree of freedom, and is not a mark of perfection but only of a shortfall in my knowledge, or a certain negation;* for if I always clearly saw what is true and good, I would never need to deliberate about a judgee to be made or a course of action to be chosen; and in that case although I would be fully free, I could never be indifferent.

Whenever the truth of a matter is not clear, I should abstain from passing judgement.

I find in myself innumerable ideas of certain things, that, even if, perhaps, they do not exist anywhere outside me, cannot yet be said to be nothing. And although, in a sense, whether I think of them or not is up to me, yet they are not inventions of my own mind, but they have true and immutable natures of their own.

It is clear that everything that's true, is something

Not only am I equally certain of the existence of God as I am of anything else that seems completely certain, but, moreover, I also observe that the certitude of all these other things depends on it so completely that without it nothing can ever be perfectly known.

Once I have perceived that God exists, then because I grasped at the same time that everything else depends on him, and that he is no deceiver, and from this deduced that everything I clearly and distinctly perceive is necessarily true, then, even if I am no longer concentrating on the reasons why I judged this to be true, provided I remember that I did see it clearly and distinctly, no contrary reason can be adduced that can induce me to doubt it; and thus I have true and certain knowledge [scientia] of it. And not only of it, but of all the other propositions I remember demonstrating at some stage.

The certitude and truth of all knowledge [scientiae] depends on the knowledge [cognitione] of the true God alone: so much so, that before I had discovered this

know-lodge, I could have no perfect knowledge [scire] of anything else at all. But now innumerable truths, concerning both, on the one hand, God himself and other intellectual things and, on the other, the whole of this bodily nature which is the object of pure mathematics,* can be plainly known to me with certainty.

Everything I have ever believed I was having a sensation of while awake, I can sometimes think I am having a sensation of while asleep; and since i do not believe that what I seem to see when asleep comes from anything existing outside me, I could not see any reason why I should believe this of the sensations I seem to have when awake.

I was still ignorant of the author of my existence, I could see no reason why I could not be so constituted by nature as to be deceived, even in things that appeared to me entirely true.

Everything I am taught by nature contains element of truth: for by nature, in a general sense, I now mean other than either God himself, or the system of created established by God; and by my own nature in particular, mean nothing other than the combination of all the properties bestowed on me by God.

I realize that there is a massive difference between sleeping and being awake, inasmuch as dreams are never combined by my memory with the rest of the actions of my life, as happens with my waking experiences. For certainly if, while I was awake, someone suddenly appeared before me, and then immediately disappeared, as happens in dreams, such a way, I mean, that I could not see where

he was coming from or where he was going, I would not unreasonably judge it to go an apparition or a delusion produced by my brain, rather than a real person. But when things happen to me in such a way that I am distinctly aware of whence, where, and when they have come, and I connect the perception of them to the rest of my life, without any gaps, then I am well and truly certain that they are happening not in my sleep but when I am awake.